

Australopithecus

Today, all ape species (except for humans) live in forests, but four million years ago things were different. Africa was home to a range of apes that lived on open ground and walked upright as we do. The best known of these walking apes, *Australopithecus*, is probably our own ancestor.

Australopithecus

OSS-tra-low-PITH-ee-cuss



- **When** 4–2 million years ago (Neogene)
- **Fossil location** Africa
- **Habitat** Open woodland, grassland
- **Height** 4–4½ ft (1.2–1.4 m)
- **Diet** Fruit, seeds, roots, insects, small animals

In many ways, *Australopithecus* was like its very close relative the chimpanzee. It had a small, hair-covered body, powerful arms for climbing, and a brain one-third the size of ours. However, its hip bones and feet were like those of modern humans, indicating that *Australopithecus* could walk upright, although less nimbly than we can. Some scientists think *Australopithecus* lived in social groups like those of gorillas, ruled by a single male that was much larger than the females.

▲ **HANDS FREE** Walking on only two feet left the arms free for other jobs, such as carrying. This was to be very important later in human evolution, when our ancestors made tools such as hunting weapons.

